

Australia and New Zealand

Rabaul

Location At the eastern end of New Britain island, Papua New Guinea

The large caldera at Rabaul was created about 1,400 years ago. Subsequently, a large breach

on the eastern side flooded most of the caldera, which became Blanche Bay, a sheltered inlet of the Bismarck Sea. Three small volcanoes lie just outside the rim of the caldera, and in 1994 (after a long period of inactivity) two of these—Tavurvur and Vulcan—erupted violently, destroying much of Rabaul town, which had developed as a port within the caldera. Tavurvur remains the most active vent, continuously emitting ash.

The Bungle Bungles

Location Northeast Western Australia, Australia

The horizontally striped, beehive-shaped towers of this range form the most impressive sandstone karst landscape in the world. Deposited 360 million years ago, before being uplifted, the sandstone has been worn away by the combined effects of heavy

rainfall, chemical weathering, and erosion by the wind. These have cut gullies and gorges, such as Cathedral Gorge. The orange layers of sandstone contain oxidized iron compounds and do not retain water. The gray layers contain more clay and so retain more moisture, supporting cyanobacteria that protect the surface of the sandstone.

▼ STRIATED SANDSTONES AT THE BUNGLE BUNGLES

